

CASE STUDY 02

The Funding Gap: Redesigning the Entrepreneur Financing Experience

When the system meant to help entrepreneurs grow becomes the biggest barrier to their growth.

Domain	FinTech / Entrepreneurship / Development Finance
Methods	User interviews, Problem framing, Service blueprint, Opportunity mapping
Deliverables	Research synthesis, Redesigned funding journey, Dashboard prototype

01 - The Observation That Started It All

"When entrepreneurs need a large amount to scale, funders ask them to prove themselves with a tiny fraction of it - even after years of doing exactly that. They get stuck in endless training programs with no guarantee of receiving funds. They cannot grow because the system keeps them small."
— Synthesis of real entrepreneur testimonials

This pattern affects thousands of entrepreneurs across West Africa and beyond. Funding programs designed to help end up creating a new kind of trap: the proof-of-concept loop.

02 - Understanding the Problem

The Proof-of-Concept Trap

Entrepreneurs in the scaling phase need significant capital (\$50,000) to execute their next stage. Funders, however, ask them to start with \$5,000 - something the entrepreneur has already proven at. This creates a cycle:

The Cycle	The Real Cost
Prove yourself at small scale	Lost market opportunities
Apply for larger funding	Operational stagnation
Get asked to prove at small scale again	Founder burnout
Attend months of mandatory training	Wasted months of training time
No guarantee of final funding	Demoralization and dropout
Restart the cycle	Economic potential unrealized

03 - Who Is Affected?

Persona A: Aïcha, 34	Persona B: Mamadou, 41
Has run a food processing business for 5 years	Agricultural cooperative leader
Revenue: \$2,000/month, consistent	Manages 120 farmers, has proven supply chain
Needs \$40,000 to buy equipment and scale	Needs \$80,000 for cold storage infrastructure
Has completed 3 funding programs	Was asked to start with \$8,000 pilot again
Still has not received the capital she needs	Missed a major export contract while waiting

04 - The Insight

Core Insight

Funding systems are designed for risk reduction - not for entrepreneur growth. They measure ability to comply with program structures rather than demonstrated business performance. The result: the entrepreneurs most ready for capital are paradoxically the least able to access it.

05 - Design Solution

I designed an Entrepreneur Capital Readiness Platform - a digital tool that replaces training gatekeeping with evidence-based assessment and transparent matching.

Key Features

- Business profile with revenue history, track record, and growth plan - replacing generic applications
- AI-assisted capital readiness score - transparent criteria, no black box
- Direct funder matching based on business stage, sector, and funding size
- Optional (not mandatory) learning modules - chosen by the entrepreneur, not imposed
- Progress dashboard - real-time status, clear next steps, no silence

06 - Impact and Outcomes

Before	After (Designed)
Generic application forms	Business performance profile
Mandatory multi-month training	Optional, targeted learning
Unknown evaluation criteria	Transparent readiness score
Weeks of silence after applying	Real-time tracking dashboard
Repeat the loop from scratch	Progress carries across applications

07 - Key Learnings

The most valuable UX discovery here was realizing that the 'user' in this system has two faces: the entrepreneur seeking capital, and the funder managing risk. A good solution must serve both - making it easier for funders to identify quality investments, while removing arbitrary barriers for entrepreneurs. Trust, transparency, and evidence are the design values that connect both sides.